cultural centers, which adversely affected American facilities more than Soviet ones.[121] The administration conveyed its displeasure but without "blowing up a major storm in US-Indian relations."[122]

The desire to limit damage to the US-India relationship also showed in the option the president chose to "do something" for Pakistan to help his China policy. In spring 1970, Nixon indicated that in considering military supply to Pakistan, he wanted a policy that was "less provocative politically in the US and for that matter in India." Kissinger presented the president with the options of relaxing the arms embargo on Pakistan or retaining it while approving a one-time exception to sell "a few items." Kissinger recommended the latter option and Nixon approved it, knowing that Pakistan would have preferred the first option.[123]

The US announcement of the one-time exception in fall 1970 made Indian officials unhappy, but as an American official noticed, their public reaction was not as angry or sustained as expected. Internally, foreign secretary T. N. Kaul scoffed at the American idea that India should appreciate the restrained supply. But officials took Jha's advice about not "stir[ring] up public controversy beyond that generated in the Parliamentary debate."[124] The State Department noted that even that debate was "relatively muted, and considerable attention was also given to Soviet arms sales to Pakistan."[125] Those sales had indeed caused Soviet favorability among the public to decline even further in an August survey (51 percent compared with 66 percent for the US).[126]

India's relatively muted reaction to the American step was because it could not afford to lose all traction in Washington. Jha stressed to the foreign minister that the US move was limited and its motive was not "anti-Indian." He believed the decision stemmed from Pakistani lobbying, as well as the White House's "feeling that Pakistan could, perhaps, in certain circumstances serve as a middle-man to bring about rapprochement between America and China." Jha cautioned against criticism becoming "generally anti-American in tone or content." That would only further weaken the hand of India advocates in the State Department, Congress, and the media, who were already hurting from India's attitude on the Vietnam War.[127]

The need for American friendship also shaped the way India dealt with differences over US actions in Southeast Asia in 1970. Referring to some